

Transient Shaper

Quick guide for the Windows VST3 effect.

Install the VST3

1. Download the VST3 package from the project repository. Use the setup installer, or extract the VST3 ZIP if you prefer to install it manually.
2. The setup installs to the standard shared folder: C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3. It requests administrator permission. Manual installation should preserve the folder named Transient Shaper.vst3 under the VST3 directory.
3. Restart your DAW or run its plug-in rescan. Find Transient Shaper in the Dynamics or VST3 effect list and insert it on a mono or stereo track.
4. To remove the setup-installed plug-in, use its Transient Shaper VST3 entry in Windows Apps. For a manual installation, remove the Transient Shaper.vst3 folder from the VST3 directory.

The installer installs the VST3 plug-in only. Windows may show an unknown publisher prompt because this build is not code-signed.

First use

Start from Attack 0 dB, Sustain 0 dB, Sensitivity 1.00x, and Output 0 dB. Increase Attack to bring transients forward. Lower Sustain if you want the body of the sound quieter. Adjust Sensitivity to change how strongly the detector classifies fast level rises as transients. Use Output to compensate for the resulting loudness change.

The signal path



The interface uses a Windows XP inspired blue bevel theme with teal and magenta accents. The live graph illustrates the Attack/Sustain shape and places a marker using the detector activity value; it is not a waveform, spectrum or frequency response display.

Controls

Control	Range / default	What it changes
Attack	-12 to +12 dB Default: 0 dB	Gain applied in proportion to the detected transient weight. Positive values emphasize the onset; negative values soften it.
Sustain	-12 to +12 dB Default: 0 dB	Gain applied to the portion weighted as signal body. Positive values lift the body; negative values reduce it.
Sensitivity	0.25x to 4.0x Default: 1.00x	Scales the fast-versus-body envelope difference before it is clamped to a 0-1 transient weight. Higher values increase transient weighting. It is not a threshold in dB.
Output	-12 to +12 dB Default: 0 dB	Post-shaper output trim. Use it to recover or reduce level after changing Attack or Sustain.

Practical workflow

- For sharper drums, try Attack +3 dB and Sustain -2 dB, then adjust Sensitivity until the detector follows the hits you want to shape.
- For softer transients, move Attack below 0 dB. Keep Sustain near 0 dB if you want the body level unchanged.
- For longer or more present body, raise Sustain gradually. Watch peak level and lower Output if needed.
- Compare with the DAW's bypass at a similar loudness. A louder setting can seem better even when the transient balance is not.

This version has no user controls for detector attack/release time, threshold, ratio, mix, or sidechain. The detector times are fixed in the DSP.

Meters and troubleshooting

The header shows input and output peak readings in dBFS. The detector graphic animates at about 24 updates per second and follows the average transient activity reported by the audio callback. The VST3 reports zero latency and no tail; the host may still add its own track or routing delay.

If the plug-in is missing

- Check that the VST3 bundle is inside the folder your DAW scans. The default shared Windows folder is C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3.
- Restart the DAW and use its rescan or clear-cache command. Some DAWs cache failed scans until restarted.
- Confirm the host supports 64-bit Windows VST3 plug-ins and is scanning the VST3 format, not VST2.

If installation fails

- Close the DAW before replacing a plug-in file. The host may keep the module loaded and lock it.
- Use an account allowed to install to Program Files. The setup requests administrator permission for the standard shared folder.

Project and support

The source code, build instructions, VST3 package and releases are published at <https://github.com/amitabhsarkarwya/transient>. Report reproducible problems with the DAW name, Windows version, plug-in version and steps that lead to the issue.

Version 0.0.1 | Built for Windows x64 VST3 | Prepared 23 September 2026